

Hum Log was the first Indian soap opera, and it glued the nation to its television sets. It was modelled on a Mexican TV series, *Ven Conmigo* (1975), which used entertainment to deliver educational messages. The idea came to information and broadcasting minister Vasant Sathe after he visited Mexico in 1982. The series was scripted by noted writer Manohar Shyam Joshi, and directed by P. Kumar Vasudev. The telecast began on July 7, 1984 and the series ran till the end of 1985, with three half-hour episodes broadcast every week. Each of the episodes ended with an analysis by actor Ashok Kumar. *Hum Log* brought together the best theatrical talent in Delhi, tackled a wide range of social issues, and gave us some of our most memorable TV characters and moments.

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Of course, the growth of television was paralleled by a burgeoning market for TV sets. A mere 404 TV licences were issued in 1965. This shot to 455,430 in 1975. The number of sets totalled 5.2 million when the licencing system was abolished in early 1985. That year, two million TV sets were sold in India, with 800,000 of them being colour sets (put another way, four Indian homes were acquiring a TV set every minute, as per an INDIA TODAY story). ■

The Video Invasion
June 30, 1983

"There is little reason why a video revolution should sweep through India. Few video cassette recorders (VCRs) are manufactured in the country, imports are restricted, and prices are high—a VCR and colour television set together cost as much as a year's salary for the middle class Indian. It's not just the rich, and it's not just the metropolises; if anything, the VCR has conquered small towns and semi-urban areas. The Film Federation of India found after a recent survey that the "video menace" had spread to 400 towns, ranging from urban clusters in the Jharia coal belt to Bhusawal in Maharashtra, Churu in Rajasthan, Deogarh in Bihar, and tiny coastal settlements in Kerala and Karnataka."

